The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

America and **Israel** launched an attack on **Iran**. Several missiles struck Tehran, the capital, including the military headquarters and the offices of the supreme leader, as well as other military sites. Iran's national security council told residents of Tehran to leave the city. Iranian media said Ayatollah Ali Khamenei was in a safe, undisclosed location. Israel called the attack "pre-emptive", claiming it would "remove threats to the state of Israel".

President Donald Trump made an expansive case for "major combat operations", laying out a litany of Iranian misdeeds from the country's takeover of America's embassy in Tehran in 1979 to its support for Hamas. He called on the Revolutionary Guard, ordinary soldiers and police to lay down their arms and receive immunity or else face "certain death", and told the Iranian people "when we are finished, take over your government." He warned Americans that they "may have casualties".

Iran fired several missiles at **Israel** in response, though most seem to have been intercepted by the country's defence systems. Israel banned public gatherings, shut schools and offices and declared a state of emergency. **Binyamin Netanyahu**, the prime minister, warned that Israelis would need to show "endurance and fortitude".

Meanwhile **Qatar's** government said it had shot down Iranian missiles over its territory, and **Bahrain's** government said Iranian missiles had hit a base that had served as the headquarters of the US Navy's Fifth Fleet. Earlier this week, media reported that America had moved its vessels from the location. There were also explosions in Abu Dhabi, where one person was reportedly killed; Riyadh, in Saudi Arabia; and Kuwait.

Among America's Western **allies**, the European Union excoriated Iran, which "has killed thousands", but expressed a fear of escalation. Britain said it did not want to see a wider conflict. Spain outright "rejected" the strikes and called for de-escalation, while Australia said it supported America's acting to stop Iran getting nuclear weapons.

Meanwhile **Pakistan** "strongly condemned" the "unwarranted attacks" on next-door Iran, and **Russia**, another neighbour, also called for an immediate halt to the strikes, which it said were irresponsible. Indonesia, the world's biggest Muslim-majority country, offered to mediate.

Reza Pahlavi, the son of the last shah of Iran, released a message to Iranians imploring them to take to the streets. He also called on the police and security forces to break from the clerical regime. Mr Pahlavi, who lives in America, has tried to present himself as an alternative to the regime, though Iran's opposition movements remain wary of him.

Photograph: Reuters

The strikes Iran has been bracing for

America and Israel launched a long-awaited war against Iran on Saturday morning, in broad daylight. Their strikes came after months of gunboat diplomacy, and despite an Iranian offer brokered by Oman to close its key nuclear installations. Donald Trump promised to “raze” Iran’s missile forces, “annihilate” its navy and ensure that its regional “proxies” would no longer present a threat. He urged Iranians to rise up and topple the regime, arguing: “This will be probably your only chance for generations.”

Footage from Iran showed attacks on the presidential palace and the complex of the supreme leader, as well as multiple military bases. The country’s internet was largely shut off once again. Iran promised “crushing retaliation”. Israel’s armed forces said they had detected incoming Iranian missiles, triggering alerts throughout the country. Missiles were also intercepted over Gulf countries including Qatar, Kuwait and Bahrain.

Photograph: AP

Violence resumes on Afghanistan and Pakistan’s border

“Our patience has now run out,” declared Pakistan’s defence minister, Khawaja Muhammad Asif. “Now it is open war.” The already fragile ceasefire between Pakistan and Afghanistan collapsed this week as Pakistan launched air strikes on Afghan cities including Kabul, its capital. The bombardment followed days of lethal border skirmishes.

Pakistan accuses Afghanistan’s Taliban government of harbouring and supporting its offshoot, the Pakistani Taliban, which has unleashed a wave of violence. Militant attacks in Pakistan have increased every year since the Taliban took over Afghanistan in August 2021; last year they surged to their highest level since 2015. Turkey and Qatar mediated the last ceasefire, after fighting erupted in October, and are reportedly trying to get both sides to de-escalate. The Taliban says it wants the fighting to be “resolved through dialogue”, but Pakistan says Afghanistan must make a “clear choice” between standing with terrorists and with Pakistan.

Photograph: AP

Investors’ first glimpse of Buffett-less Berkshire

Berkshire Hathaway, America’s ninth most valuable firm and last truly sprawling industrial conglomerate, has revolved around Warren Buffett since he took control of the company in 1965. His annual shareholder letter has been a must-read for investors ever since: Mr Buffett is probably American capitalism’s most successful stock-picker and certainly its most enduring narrator. But in December the 95-year-old “oracle of Omaha” retired.

On Saturday Berkshire will publish a letter penned for the first time by Greg Abel, Mr Buffett’s successor. So far there have been a few hints of how Berkshire might change after the retirement of its singular leader. Shareholders will be interested to see how Mr Abel’s prose compares. But what they really want to know are his plans for the $380bn of cash on Berkshire’s balance sheet. As interest rates come down, the cost of inaction grows. Mr Abel could spend it on deals, or return it to shareholders. Either way, shareholders are expecting answers.

Photograph: AP

Mark Carney’s mission to trade with the world

Canada’s relationship with the United States is changing. In 2024 Canada sent more than three-quarters of its exports to its neighbour, but that number has since been sliding. Last year, as Donald Trump imposed stiff tariffs and other economic penalties in a vainglorious attempt to turn Canada into America’s 51st state, Mark Carney won his Liberal Party an unlikely fourth consecutive term.

Since then Mr Carney has been on a mission to drum up foreign investment and trade from elsewhere. He recently announced partnerships with China and Qatar. At the World Economic Forum in Davos, he exhorted like-minded middle powers to stitch together a trading coalition in the face of Mr Trump’s tariffs. This week Mr Carney landed in India, where he is expected to sign a range of deals, including to sell C$3.9bn-worth ($2.8bn) of Canadian uranium to fuel India’s nuclear-power expansion. After that he will travel to Australia and Japan. The world tour continues.

Photograph: AP

Weekend profile: Ali Larijani, the man who seems to be running Iran

Editor's note: *This profile was published before the American-Israeli strikes on Iran began on February 28th.*

When is Iran's supreme leader not supreme? When he has delegated his authority to someone else. Under the constitution of the Islamic Republic of Iran, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei may devolve his power. But the octogenarian has never shed so much of it as he has done recently. Now Ali Larijani, a mandarin with an independent streak, appears to be in charge of the questions that matter most.

Mr Larijani's rise may be a sign of Mr Khamenei's loss of confidence in clerics and generals after a series of military and internal setbacks. Since the revolution of 1979, turbanned clerics have ruled Iran. Commanders from the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps managed the battlefield. But Mr Larijani is neither. Though a former guardsman born of clerical stock, he is an academic by training—a mathematician who lectured on Immanuel Kant at Tehran University. He has family in Britain and America. In a country where officials wear starched white shirts buttoned to the neck, he favours black shirts with buttons undone in the style of Johnny Cash.

Iran-watchers began detecting the change during Iran's summer war, which Israel began by targeting Iran's top commanders. Fearing he might be next, Mr Khamenei went into hiding—and has mostly remained there since. In August he formally appointed Mr Larijani as secretary of the Supreme National Security Council.

It caps a curious career. As a young official Mr Larijani was known as an austere fundamentalist. As culture minister and then head of state broadcasting, he marginalised reformists and aired their forced confessions. By the mid-2000s, however, he had edged towards pragmatism. He took part in early nuclear talks with Europe, opposed the rigged re-election of the hardline populist president, Mahmoud Ahmadinejad, and helped secure ratification of the 2015 nuclear deal. For this flexibility he has paid a price: hardliners accused him of corruption, in effect forced his brother out from the judiciary and twice barred him from running for president.

Does Mr Larijani's return herald Iran's shift from a theocracy towards something more technocratic? As a regime careerist, he will do little to assuage Iranians enraged by last month's bloody suppression of protests. Yet few others possess the pedigree to coax the regime's bastions of power into line—or to persuade Western negotiators that the regime is serious about burying the hatchet with America. If Iran is on the cusp of becoming a post-Islamic republic, Mr Larijani might yet be the regime's choice for supreme leader.

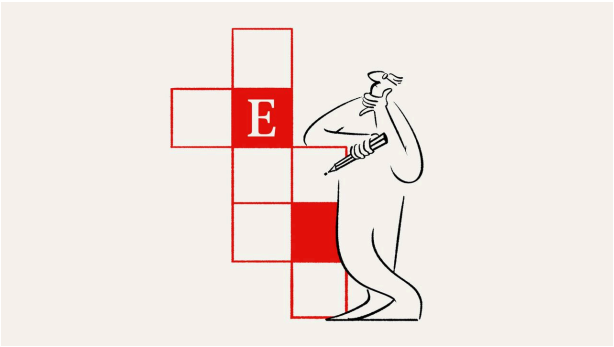

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - As war minister, he gets hydrogen explosion (7)

2 across - Zagreb resident travels around Belgium as a tumbler (7)

3 across - Welsh tribe ripe, in part, for reverse renaissance (7)

1 down - Misanthrope swallows nice new ball, spinning—and his own kind (8,6)

Straight clues

1 across - He's taking the war to Anthropic (7)

2 across - A well-known PDF reader (7)

3 across - "A ------- of hope", promises Donald Trump, "in our neglected inner cities" (7)

1 down - An antihero with a grisly allure (8,6)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Anneli Hildeman, Brussels, Belgium

Ozlem Sumnu, Barcelona, Spain

Bruce Fink, Honolulu, Hawaii, America

They all gave the correct answers of: Henry Kissinger, Woodrow Wilson, Martin Luther King junior, Linus Pauling and Al Gore. The theme is that they were all American winners of the Nobel peace prize.

The questions were:

Monday: Which American statesman who was secretary of state under Richard Nixon died in 2023 at the age of 100?

Tuesday: Which American statesman helped create the League of Nations, although he failed to persuade America to join?

Wednesday: In America, the third Monday of January is a federal holiday named after which civil-rights activist?

Thursday: Which prominent scientist, who helped explain that sickle cell anemia was caused by an abnormal protein, became an advocate for taking high doses of vitamin C?

Friday: Who wrote “An Inconvenient Truth”, a book about climate change?

I’m glad you like adverbs — I adore them; they are the only qualifications I really much respect.

Henry James